FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Kim Namjoon! Kim Seokjin! Min Yoongi! Jung Hoseok! Park Jimin! Kim Taehyung! Jeon Jungkook! These are not names one might expect to hear chanted in India, and would doubtless leave most of our population baffled. But there's a swelling cohort in our midst for whom these names point to celestial bodies that form the very centre of their universe. Members of the Korean boy band BTS, with a crazed global following akin to Beatlemania, the 'Bangtan Boys' now command a massive desi fanbase. They attract tens of millions of hits from India on YouTube and Spotify, consistently among their top global numbers. But culturally speaking, they are no solo act. They lead what amounts to a full-fledged Korean wave in India. We are calling it *The K-Craze*.

Music, or K-Pop, is only one aspect of a many-faceted infatuation: it encompasses the wildly popular K-dramas, K-cuisine, fashion and apparel, the Korean beauty and skincare industry and its widely admired ethos, extending all the way to a growing desire to learn the language and to travel to the country itself.

It is a global pop culture tsunami whose first landfall was in other East Asian countries, in the early days of satellite media. The wild popularity of Korean content among Chinese youth gave it its name, the *Hallyu* wave, now used worldwide. Over the past decade, despite the much larger cultural and linguistic chasm, the phenomenon has started washing up on our shores. By now, it has left an indelible footprint, with astounding reach across class and geography. At one end are the ultra-cosmopolitan millennials and Gen-Zers. But strikingly, you also have innumerable faceless youngsters from India's fast-modernising hinterland, like H. Subhashree, a 31-year-old nurse from Bolangir, Odisha, who, by now, knows as much Korean as she does English, acquired solely through her staple diet of K-dramas and K-Pop. The phenomenon is a fascinating window to how low-cost WiFi and access to online platforms are levelling the field and creating a more uniformly globalised public in India.

According to a 2024 'Overseas Hallyu survey' by the South Korean government, India now ranks among the top 'K-crazed' countries. The latest edition of the All India K-Pop Contest, held annually since 2011, saw an astounding 1,278 teams participate in regional rounds, from big cities to Itanagar. Beyond music, Korean entertainment is a full cosmos, and India is voyaging through all parts of it. K-dramas, with their simple, universal and clean-cut romances, have millions of ordinary Indian women plugged in, subtitles and all. Korean content on OTT is viewed on average for 18.6 hours monthly, way above the global average of 11.6 hours. Korean is now the most watched non-Indian language on Netflix, after English. Season 1 of *Squid Game*, Netflix's chilling Korean survival drama, stayed in India's Top 10 for 39 weeks.

The love is out in the open, spilling into urban landscapes. Malls and fancy bazaars now feature Korea-inspired photo booths where fans strike poses with quirky props. Newly minted converts to Korea's rigorous 10-step beauty regimen swear by brands like TIRTIR, Laneige and Cosrx. Over 60 brands have wended their way to India; a Google search for a 'store near me' yields plenty of hits in the big cities, and all online platforms deliver K-beauty right at home, with Amazon registering a 75 per cent jump in the segment.

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There's every sign that the fetish has gone more than skin-deep. India has produced at least two bona fide K-Pop stars: Sriya Lenka (from Odisha) and Aria (from Kerala). Indians are now travelling to Korea for more than business; in 2024, traffic increased by 44 per cent over the previous year. A 2022 Duolingo study also ranked Korean among the top five languages studied in India. Food is another frontier. The appetite is fast-growing, even in Tier-3 cities. Sales of ramyeon instant noodles are up 56 per cent. Swiggy orders for Korean food are soaring even in places like Surat, Nashik, Kollam and Patna. Blue Tokai and Chaayos have added Korean cream cheese buns to their menu; McDonald's has experimented with K-inspired burgers. Korean restaurants, from the fancy to the modest, are everywhere.

For our cover story this week, Deputy Editor Suhani Singh and Senior Associate Editor Sonal Khetarpal track all aspects of this vast and variegated subculture. They trace its genesis to South Korea's concerted push to export its soft power globally as a desire-enhancing sauce that speeds up the uptake of its vast consumer product portfolio, from Samsung and LG electronic goods to Hyundai and Kia cars. It appears to be working, judging by how bilateral trade, expected to reach $50 billion by 2030, has a significant tilt in Korea's favour. Korean exports to India saw a staggering 37 per cent rise in the last three fiscals, to $21 billion in FY25. Cultural exports are a thing unto themselves. India has adapted to Italian pizza, Chinese noodles and Japanese sushi. Right now, Gujarat is falling for the sweet-savoury chilli of *gochujang*, Kerala digs the fermented cabbage pickle *kimchi*, and rice-loving Bihar may soon get besotted by the complex flavours of *bibimbap*.

(Aroon Purie)